

The 5-Week Micro-Automation Builder

Five small systems that local businesses will pay you a monthly fee to run. Build one a week — from zero to your first paying client.

You don't need an audience, a following, or a computer-science degree. You need one small, boring problem solved so well that a business would rather pay you monthly than keep losing time and money to it. Be the locksmith, not the handyman: fix one specific thing perfectly, and you become easy to hire and recommend.

This guide gives you five complete systems — one per week. Each week you'll build a system, land one client, then move to the next. A build takes well under an hour once you know the steps; the rest of your time goes into learning the tool and setting it up cleanly for one specific business. It's a service, not passive income — and that's exactly why it pays.

How to use this guide

One system per week. Build it, find one client, then start the next week.

The engine. A visual no-code platform connects the apps. **Make.com** is the friendly default; **Pabbly** is a lower-cost alternative; **n8n** lets you self-host if you're privacy-minded. For booking pages use **Cal.com**. **Google Sheets, Calendar, and Gmail** are free. Use **Claude or ChatGPT** for friendly wording. Prefer one dashboard for everything? **GoHighLevel** bundles the CRM, texting, calendar, and reviews together.

Map before you build. Write the flow in plain language first (WHEN this... THEN that...). If you can say it clearly, you can build it.

Mind the free tiers. No-code platforms cap monthly tasks on free plans — confirm the limit before you promise anything to a client.

Texting rule (US). Any system that texts customers needs **A2P 10DLC** registration before you go live, plus “Reply STOP to opt out” in every message. Handling that registration is itself a service you can charge for.

Some tool links in this guide may be affiliate links, at no cost to you. We only point you toward tools we'd build on ourselves. Tool names, pricing, and free-tier limits change — verify current details with each provider.

WEEK 1

Missed-Call Text-Back

The highest-ROI automation you can sell — and the easiest first “yes.”

The problem

Most local businesses miss 30–60% of their calls (busy staff, after hours), and most callers who hit voicemail never call back — they call a competitor. This texts the caller within a minute so the conversation stays alive.

Who pays for it

Plumbers, HVAC, electricians, roofers, landscapers, salons, dentists, real estate.

Map it

WHEN a call to the business goes unanswered
THEN wait ~60 seconds (a chance to grab it)
THEN text the caller a friendly “sorry we missed you”
THEN log the caller and alert the owner

Build it

- 1. Number & registration.** Set up a business number in Twilio and complete A2P 10DLC. Forward the client's line to it.
- 2. Detect the missed call.** This is the one fiddly part: Make has no native “missed call” trigger. On the Twilio number, use a short Studio flow that rings the business, watches the call status, and on *no-answer / busy* sends a webhook into your Make scenario.
- 3. Text the caller.** Add a Twilio “Send SMS” step: “Hi, this is [Business] — sorry we missed your call! How can we help? Reply STOP to opt out.”
- 4. Log & alert.** Add a Google Sheets row (time, number, “texted”) and an email/Slack note to the owner. Test by calling and not answering.

Reality check

Simplest to sell, clearest ROI. The missed-call detection is the only tricky bit — **GoHighLevel has a native “missed call” trigger**, so if you'd rather skip the Twilio flow entirely, build this one there.

Sell it: “Recover the calls you already pay marketing to generate.”

Price it: \$300–\$500 setup + \$100–\$300/mo.

WEEK 2

Instant Lead Reply (Form → Calendar + Reply)

The classic build: no website lead ever slips through on a busy day.

The problem

A lead fills out the website form; the owner copies it into a calendar hours later and types a reply — or drops it. Responding within five minutes dramatically outperforms responding in thirty.

Who pays for it

Contractors, home services, law firms, agencies, real estate — anyone running lead ads.

Map it

WHEN a new inquiry form is submitted
THEN create a calendar event (name + phone from the form)
THEN write a friendly confirmation reply (AI step)
THEN send that reply by email (and log it)

Build it

1. **Trigger.** Start a Make scenario with a Webhook (for the site form) or a Facebook Lead Ads trigger. Map name, phone, email, message.
2. **Calendar.** Add Google Calendar “Create an Event”; put the name and phone in the title so every inquiry becomes a booking placeholder.
3. **Smart reply.** Add a Claude/ChatGPT step instructed to “write a short, friendly reply confirming we received it and will call within one business day.” Tune the wording once.
4. **Send & test.** Add Gmail “Send an Email,” log the lead to a Google Sheet, then submit a fake inquiry and confirm the event appears and the email sends. (Optional: add a Twilio SMS too.)

Reality check

The build takes under an hour. The value you charge for is captured leads and hours saved — not the minutes it took you.

Sell it: “No lead slips through on a busy day.”

Price it: \$400–\$750 setup + \$150–\$300/mo.

WEEK 3

The No-Show Shield

Booking → reminders → no-show recovery → reviews, all on autopilot.

The problem

Booked clients don't show up, and an empty chair is pure lost money. Reminders cut no-shows sharply; a kind recovery nudge wins back the ones who still slip.

Who pays for it

Salons, barbers, dentists, med spas, physios, tattoo studios, detailers.

Map it

WHEN a client books
THEN log them and send a warm confirmation
THEN remind 24 hours before, then 2 hours before
THEN if they no-show, send a kind check-in + rebooking link
THEN after the visit, ask for a review

Build it

- 1. Booking capture.** Create a Cal.com booking page. Point its “booking created” webhook at a Make Webhook trigger, so each booking pushes name, phone, and time into Make.
- 2. Log & confirm.** Add a Google Sheets row (with a Status column = “booked”) — this sheet is the brain. Send a confirmation via Twilio SMS + Gmail (AI-written, with “Reply STOP”).
- 3. The reminder clock.** Make can't “sleep” for a whole day, so build a *second* scenario set to run hourly. It reads the sheet, finds anyone ~24h out (then ~2h out) and texts a reminder.
- 4. No-show + review.** When the front desk sets Status to “no-show,” branch to a kind check-in and a rebooking link. When Status = “done,” wait a couple hours and send a Google review request.

Reality check

The hourly “clock” scenario is the honest way to do timed reminders in Make. GoHighLevel can run this whole sequence natively if you prefer one platform.

Sell it: “If this saves just two no-shows a month, it more than pays for itself.”

Price it: \$400–\$600 setup + \$150–\$350/mo.

Review Request Engine

More 5-star reviews → higher local ranking → more calls.

The problem

Happy customers leave and nobody asks for a review, so the competitor with 200 reviews outranks the business with 12. Automate the ask right after the job, when satisfaction is highest.

Who pays for it

Restaurants, dentists, home services, salons, auto shops, local retail.

Map it

WHEN a job/appointment is marked complete
THEN wait 2–3 hours
THEN text/email a review request with the Google link

Build it

1. **Get the link.** Grab the client's Google "write a review" short link from their Business Profile.
2. **Trigger.** Simplest version: a Google Sheets "Watch Rows" that fires when a job is marked "complete" (or a webhook from their booking software).
3. **Ask.** After a short delay, send an SMS/email: "Thanks for choosing [Business]! A quick Google review would mean the world: [link]. Reply STOP to opt out."
4. **Optional sentiment gate (kept honest).** First ask "How did we do, 1–5?" — 4–5 get the public link; lower scores route privately to the owner so issues get fixed. The owner still sees everything; this is service recovery, not hiding complaints.

Reality check

The ROI is the ranking lift. Show before/after review counts in your monthly report and the retainer sells itself.

Sell it: "Get found first on the map by getting more 5-star reviews, automatically."

Price it: \$300–\$500 setup + \$100–\$250/mo.

Quote / Invoice Follow-Up

Most jobs are lost to silence, not price. This chases every quote for you.

The problem

A contractor or freelancer sends a quote, then gets busy and never follows up — and the deal quietly dies. Two or three polite nudges recover a surprising share of them.

Who pays for it

Contractors, freelancers, agencies, event vendors, B2B service providers.

Map it

WHEN a quote is marked “sent”

THEN +2 days: gentle check-in

THEN +5 days: “we can hold this pricing”

THEN +10 days: soft close — and stop the moment they reply or say yes

Build it

- 1. Track quotes.** A simple Google Sheet: client, email, amount, date sent, Status (open / won / lost).
- 2. Trigger.** A “Watch Rows” fires when a new quote is added with Status “open.”
- 3. Follow-up sequence.** Using the hourly clock pattern from Week 3, send Gmail nudges at +2, +5, and +10 days. Feed the job details to Claude/ChatGPT so each nudge references the specific project.
- 4. Auto-stop & report.** Halt the sequence the instant Status flips to “won” or the client replies. Track quotes-sent vs. won — that number sells the retainer by itself.

Reality check

Pitch on recovered revenue: if this closes one extra job a month, it pays for itself many times over.

Sell it: “Stop losing jobs to silence — every quote gets followed up, automatically.”

Price it: \$400–\$600 setup + \$150–\$300/mo.

LAND THE CLIENT

Outreach: show, don't pitch

You need no audience. Open a map app, search one local trade, and find businesses with a website, booking page, or contact form — they're already doing this by hand. Build a quick sample for **one** of them, record a 30-second screen video of it working with **their business name on it**, and send the note below. Showing their own problem solved, with their own name on it, is irresistible — far stronger than a pitch.

Subject: a quick something I built for [Business Name]

Hi [Name],

I put together a short demo for [Business Name]. [One line: e.g., “when someone books, it texts a confirmation, reminds them before the visit, and wins back no-shows automatically.”]

30-second video here: [link]

If you'd like it set up live, I do a one-time setup plus a small monthly to keep it running and make tweaks. Happy to walk you through it — no pressure either way.

[Your name]

Reach out to several — it's a numbers game, and a few “no thanks” replies bring you closer to the first yes. You're offering to hand back time, not to sell software.

GET PAID PROPERLY

Price & protect

Price the outcome, not the hour. A system that recovers lost leads or stops no-shows is worth a real setup fee plus a modest monthly retainer. The recurring piece is what builds steady income.

Set aside ~30% for taxes from your first invoice — this is self-employment income. (See the MoolahIQ Optimize videos and tax estimator.)

Handle access cleanly. Use proper, revocable access to a client's accounts; never store passwords carelessly. Protecting trust is half of what makes this last.

Know the free-tier limits before you promise anything, and register A2P 10DLC before sending any customer texts.

One system. One client. Then repeat — the second client is always easier than the first. For full walkthroughs, this guide, and a weekly money skill in your inbox, head to **moolahiq.com**.

MoolahIQ — helping you increase your financial IQ, one wise decision at a time.